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August 25, 2026

Editors
The Annals of Applied Statistics

Dear Editors,

Please consider our substantially revised manuscript, “The Blown Lead Paradox: A Pathwise Calibration Benchmark for Win Probability Forecasts,” for publication in *The Annals of Applied Statistics*. This submission follows manuscript AOAS2602-023.

The revision places the sports application at the center of the paper. It begins with a specific NBA collapse, explains why the eventual loser’s maximum win probability is a reverse-conditioned path statistic, and develops only the theory needed to benchmark that quantity. The empirical analysis now includes complete regular-season NFL and NBA inventories for 2018–2024, explicit feed-coverage accounting, and a fixed-clock calibration analysis connected to the sports-forecasting literature, particularly the calibration-surface approach of Yeh, Rice, and Dubin.

We have also strengthened the inferential foundation. Games sharing teams are handled with a season-stratified dyadic pigeonhole bootstrap, supported by an exchangeable-array empirical-process argument and schedule-based validation. Extensive sensitivity analyses assess feed construction, temporal dependence, and season composition. Across these analyses, the NBA feed shows an excess of severe eventual-loser peaks, while the NFL analysis finds no detected departure.

The main article now follows one continuous applied argument: the global pathwise departure, its magnitude in the 0.95 benchmark tail, and the first-crossing mechanism. Proofs, full calibration surfaces, validation results, and robustness analyses appear in the supplement. Together, these revisions make the sports application the paper’s primary focus and develop the methodology in direct response to its substantive question.

Thank you for considering the revised manuscript.

Sincerely,

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of Pennsylvania